Zen of Defence

From research and marketing to finance and the boardroom, Shilpa Choudari's journey mirrors Zen Technologies' transformation into an ambitious, multi-domain defence-tech player

BY **PALAK AGARWAL**



PHOTO BY **SHREYAS ASODHA**

87

SHILPA CHOUDARI
Whole-time Director, Zen Technologies

BEST MANAGEMENT ADVICE RECEIVED

Understanding every part of the business well enough to ask the right questions and make sound decisions

A **WELL-PAYING JOB** was her initial ambition, not entrepreneurship or corporate leadership. Today, as Whole-time Director of Zen Technologies, Shilpa Choudari is helping steer the defence technology company through its next phase of growth.

"I always thought, let me pick up some job where I get paid well," she says. Years later, she is the Whole-Time Director of Zen Technologies, helping steer a fast-growing defence technology company through its next phase of expansion.

Her career began with a brief stint at HDFC Bank, followed by a role as a research assistant at ICFAI. She joined Zen as a research associate, initially supporting its marketing team with lead generation and online research.

Gradually, she moved into marketing, working on tenders, bidding, pricing, and business opportunities. After taking a career break, she returned to Zen in 2020 when it was a listed entity and when the company was looking to strengthen its finance function amid the disruption caused by Covid-19.

Finance subsequently became one of her core responsibilities, alongside operations and order execution.

Choudari identifies one decision as particularly consequential: Zen's willingness to move away from its traditionally cautious approach and make larger technology bets. "We felt we were playing too safely," she says. The company subsequently entered the counter-drone segment, an expensive and R&D-intensive area that has since become a key growth driver.

Choudari's professional ambition and personal philosophy converge around the idea of building something that lasts. **BT**

@palakagarwal64

NOTE *The rank is based on* BT*'s proprietary methodology involving profit after tax, profit growth, and operating profit margin, focusing on profitability as the key metric to judge performance*